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International Refugee Assistance Project: State and Local Officials From All 50 States Sign Bipartisan Letter Urging Biden Administration to Increase Refugee Admissions

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NEW YORK, Sept. 22 (TNSPol) -- The International Refugee Assistance Project issued the following news release on Sept. 21, 2021:

The Refugee Advocacy Lab published a letter signed by more than 300 state and local elected officials from all 50 states and the District of Columbia urging President Biden to resettle at least 125,000 refugees in Fiscal Year 2022. In the bipartisan letter, the officials expressed their strong support for resettling refugees in their communities. Yesterday, the Biden administration announced its intention to raise the Presidential Determination on Refugee Resettlement to 125,000, a goal advocates and officials hope will be reflected in actual resettlement numbers. While President Biden raised the refugee admissions target in Fiscal Year 2021 to 62,500, as of August 31, fewer than 8,000 refugees have been resettled in the United States.

The letter was organized by the Refugee Advocacy Lab, an initiative hosted at Refugees International and co-founded by the International Refugee Assistance Project (IRAP), International Rescue Committee (IRC), and Refugee Congress. Many signatories included messages highlighting the vital role refugees play in their communities.

Colorado Governor Jared Polis said, "More than 60,000 refugees have arrived in Colorado since 1980, and we are thankful for their continued contributions to our great state. Today, there are more displaced people in the world than at any other point in history, including tens of thousands of Afghans who assisted the American mission in Afghanistan, and we urge the Biden administration to resettle 125,000 refugees next year. Colorado is a leader in refugee resettlement and integration, and we stand ready to welcome these individuals and families."

Thirty-five mayors signed the letter, including Bill de Blasio of New York City, Lori E. Lightfoot of Chicago, Michael Hancock of Denver, John Cooper of Nashville, Kim Janey of Boston, Libby Schaaf of Oakland, William Peduto of Pittsburgh, Steve Schewel of Durham, Buddy Dyer of Orlando, Lauren McLean of Boise, and Chokwe Lumumba of Jackson.

Signatories also include city council members, state legislators, and other state and local elected leaders from all levels of government and across party lines.

Utah State Representative Dan Johnson (R) said, "We are a great country. Providing opportunities to [the] less fortunate in the world is simply the right thing to do. I believe we have the capacity to effectively engage with a larger number of refugees and immigrants."

Colorado State Representative Naquetta Ricks (D) said, "As a young girl, my family and I fled a Civil War in our native country, Liberia, and resettled as refugees in Aurora, Colorado. Since then, I have been able to live out the promises of America: I have attended university, started my own thriving small mortgage business, raised a wonderful daughter, and I am now the first ever African immigrant to serve in the Colorado legislature. Refugees like me bring heart, innovation, economic invigoration, and cultural vitality to our communities. We are fundamental to the fabric of this nation, and we ask President Biden to restore our nation's promise of welcoming and resettling refugees."

The letter's organizers celebrated the support of officials at every level of government to welcome refugees and called on the Biden administration to back up this commitment with action.

IRAP Senior Policy Counsel and Policy Advisor of the Refugee Advocacy Lab Balqees Mihirig said, "Officials from

around the country came together to deliver a powerful message: refugees are welcome here. Now it is time for the Biden administration to make good on its promise to resettle at least 125,000 refugees. The number of refugees resettled this fiscal year fell significantly short of the administration's target, highlighting the desperate need for substantial investments in the U.S. resettlement program to support refugees and the communities that welcome them."

Refugees International Communications Director and Interim Director of the Refugee Advocacy Lab Sarah Sheffer said, "As the crisis in Afghanistan unfolds and the number of people worldwide in urgent need of protection rises, Americans in every corner of the country are stepping up to welcome our new neighbors so that they can begin rebuilding their lives and become integral parts of our communities. We join elected officials, Americans, and advocates across the country in asking the Biden administration to meet this moment with the leadership and bold action it requires by significantly increasing the Presidential Determination."

International Rescue Committee Director, State Advocacy and State Strategic Lead of the Refugee Advocacy Lab Genevieve Kessler said, "Our state and local elected leaders know that their communities are enriched by a robust resettlement program. In the last year, state legislators introduced--and passed--dozens of measures to welcome refugees and support their integration through workforce development, strengthened language access policies, and other methods. The bipartisan support of this letter reaffirms what we know to be true--that communities welcome refugees."

* * *

To: President Joseph R. Biden Jr., The White House, 1600 Pennsylvania Avenue NW, Washington, D.C. 20500

Dear Mr. President:

As leaders in our communities, elected at all levels of state and local government, we write today to express our strong support for protecting and resettling refugees in our states and communities. We call on your Administration to prioritize restoring our nation's refugee resettlement infrastructure as quickly as possible and to fulfill your pledge to admit 125,000 refugees in Fiscal Year 2022.

Refugee resettlement is not only a lifeline for refugees, but it also revitalizes our communities--strengthening our economies and civic institutions. We urge you to consider the voices of communities across the country as we join together in support of this life-saving and life-giving program. Preserving and enhancing refugee resettlement is key to effectively and humanely responding to emergency refugee situations. An immediate and urgent example is the recent announcement by your Administration of a new mechanism for refugee protection for certain Afghans, whose lives are at risk as the United States withdraws from Afghanistan. Having the requisite resources at the ready is necessary for these very moments.

The international community faces a forced migration crisis of historic proportions that requires bold leadership, innovative solutions, and all countries to do their fair share. The United Nations Refugee Agency (UNHCR) reports that over 82.4 million people are forcibly displaced worldwide, 26.4 million of whom are registered as refugees. More than half of those registered are children. For a small minority facing specific risks, staying in their initial host country is not an option, making resettlement necessary. The UNHCR estimates that 1.47 million refugees need access to resettlement this year. Despite this, only a tiny fraction is afforded this chance.

The COVID-19 pandemic has further exacerbated this crisis, as many refugees awaiting resettlement are left in limbo due to travel restrictions and abrupt flight cancellations. As a result, only 34,400 refugees were resettled globally last year--the lowest number in two decades. Moreover, while we applaud increasing this year's refugee admissions goal to 65,200, we are disappointingly on pace to reach only a fraction of that number. As international travel resumes and health checks are implemented, we hope resettlement is accelerated in this time of great need, and that public health and protecting refugees are not treated as mutually exclusive.

On this 70th anniversary of the 1951 Refugee Convention, we have a chance to affirm our commitments to the

world and to this nation by welcoming 125,000 refugees into our communities. As elected leaders, we continually hear from our constituents that they support the resettlement of refugees. From greeting refugee families at the airport to assisting with English language classes or navigating bus lines - our communities stand for welcome. They know that refugees are men, women, and children who were forced to flee in order to save their lives and are now looking for a place to be safe and call home again.

Refugees bring immense value to our communities. They invigorate our economies, bring innovation to our towns, and make our public and cultural institutions richer. Refugees are students, business owners, dedicated employees, customers, elected officials, and community leaders. In every way, they embody what it means to be an American.

Refugees and their families bring so much to our communities, and we are better and stronger because of them. As state and local elected officials, we encourage you to restore our nation's standing as a leader in welcoming refugees by fulfilling your promise to resettle 125,000 refugees in the coming year.

We hope that you will take into account our strong desire to welcome refugees as you make your determination.

Sincerely,

Alabama

Neil Rafferty, State Representative, Birmingham

Alaska

Elvi Gray-Jackson, State Senator, Anchorage

Arizona

Ylenia Aguilar, School Board Member, Phoenix

Richard Andrade, State Representative, Phoenix

Andres Cano, State Representative, Tucson

Sophia Carrillo Dahl, School Board Member, Phoenix

Andrea Dalessandro, State Representative, Tucson

Rosanna Gabaldon, State Senator, Sahuarita

Carlos Garcia, Vice Mayor, Phoenix

Betty Guardado, City Councilwoman, Phoenix

Lauren Kuby, Councilmember, Tempe

Stanford Prescott, Governing Board Member, Phoenix Union High School District, Phoenix

Martin Quezada, State Senator, Phoenix

Athena Salman, State Representative, Tempe

Stephanie Stahl Hamilton, State Representative, Tucson

Raquel Teran, State Representative, Phoenix

Arkansas

Lioneld Jordan, Mayor, Fayetteville

Holly Hertzberg, Councilmember, Fayetteville

Teresa Turk, Councilmember, Fayetteville

California

John Bauters, City Council Member, Emeryville

Marc Berman, Assemblymember, Menlo Park

Tygarjas Bigstyck, City Council Member, Pacifica

Bob Blumenfield, Los Angeles City Councilmember, Los Angeles

John Erickson, Councilmember, West Hollywood

Jesse Gabriel, Assemblymember, Encino

Farrah Khan, Mayor, Irvine

Libby Schaaf, Mayor, Oakland

Sepi Shyne, Councilmember, West Hollywood

Henry Stern, State Senator, Calabasas

Connor Traut, Mayor, Buena Park

Christopher Ward, Assemblymember, San Diego

Scott Wiener, State Senator, San Francisco

Colorado

Governor Jared Polis

Yadira Caraveo, State Representative, Thornton

John Clark, Mayor, Ridgway

Todd Cohen, Councilmember, Broomfield

Hannah Gay Keao, City Councilwoman, Edgewater

Stacie Gilmore, Denver City Council President, Denver

Julie Gonzales, State Senator, Denver

Michael Hancock, Mayor, Denver

Iman Jodeh, Assemblymember, Aurora

Laura Keegan, Mayor, Edgewater

John Kefalas, County Commissioner, Fort Collins

Chris Kennedy, State Representative, Lakewood

Robin Kniech, City Councilmember, Denver

Naquetta Ricks, State Representative, Aurora

Sam Weaver, Mayor, Boulder

Connecticut

Luke A. Bronin, Mayor, Hartford

Edwin Vargas, State Representative, Hartford

Delaware

Paul Baumbach, State Representative, Newark

District of Columbia

Brianne K. Nadeau, Councilmember, Washington

Florida

Trish Becker, Special District Mosquito County Commissioner, St. Augustine

Buddy Dyer, Mayor, Orlando

Anna Eskamani, State Representative, Orlando

Dotie Joseph, State Representative, North Miami

Sarah Leonardi, School Board Member, Pompano Beach

Carlos G. Smith, State Representative, Orlando

Georgia

Becky Evans, State Representative, Atlanta

Anthony Ford, Mayor, Stockbridge

Kim Jackson, State Senator, Stone Mountain

Angelika Kausche, State Representative, Johns Creek

Hawaii

Stanley Chang, State Senator, Honolulu

Tina Wildberger, State Representative, Kihei

Idaho

Sue Chew, State Representative, Boise

Chris Mathias, State Representative, Boise

Lauren McLean, Mayor, Boise

Colin Nash State Representative Boise

Lauren Necochea State Representative Boise

Melissa Wintrow, State Senator, Boise

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Kelly Cassidy, State Representative, Chicago

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Michael Crowner, Township Supervisor, Wheatland Township

Daniel Didech, State Representative, Buffalo Grove

Laura Fine, State Senator, Glenview

Will Guzzardi, State Representative, Chicago

Maria Hadden, Alderwoman, Chicago

Ian Holzhauer, Councilman, Naperville

Daniel La Spata, Alderperson, Chicago

Lori E. Lightfoot, Mayor, Chicago

Meta Mueller, County Commissioner, Aurora, Will County

Rossana Rodriguez-Sanchez, Alderperson, Chicago

Jacqueline Traynere, County Commissioner, Bolingbrook, Will County

Andre Vasquez, Alderman, 40th Ward, Chicago

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John Doll, State Senator, Garden City

Mary Ware, State Senator, Wichita

Kentucky

Josie Raymond, State Representative, Louisville

Susan Westrom, State Representative, Lexington

Louisiana

Karen Peterson, State Senator, New Orleans

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Denise Tepler, State Representative, Topsham

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Jessica Feldmark, Delegate, District 12, Howard and Baltimore Counties

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Anne Kaiser, Delegate, Silver Spring

Kacy Kostiuk, City Councilmember, Takoma Park

David Moon, Delegate, Silver Spring

Julie Palakovich Carr, Delegate, Rockville

Sheila Ruth, Delegate, Catonsville

Emily Shetty, Delegate, Annapolis

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Vaughn Stewart, Delegate, District 19, Montgomery County

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Christine Barber, State Representative, Somerville

Fred Baron, Selectboard, Whately

Zac Bears, City Councilor, Medford

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Harriette Chandler, State Senator, Boston

Sonia Chang-Diaz, State Senator, Boston

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Javier Valdez, State Representative, Seattle

Girmay Zahilay, Councilmember, Seattle

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Alex Joers, County Supervisor, Middleton

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Wyoming

Mike Yin, State Representative, Jackson

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